Level 5 Adult ESL Curriculum · Lesson 10 (Week 11): Can We Meet in the Middle?

Status: Published. Listening audio, lesson pages, and teacher slides are ready.

Date: October 2026

Audience: Volunteer teachers and adult learners

Companion files: images/ (12 vocabulary pictures + images/CREDITS_L5_L10.md). Listening audio: L5_L10_listening.mp3 (2:11).

> **Topic:** Two coworkers share a Saturday job. They disagree, then meet in the middle. The conflict is a schedule between coworkers, not a complaint against a boss and not a pay dispute.

How this lesson is organized

Part	What's inside	Who uses it
Teacher Plan	At a glance, clock, steps, listening script, answer key, notes	Volunteer teachers
Student Pages	Opening Talk, New Words, Listening, Grammar, Talk Time, Homework, Read & Write, Exit Ticket	Learners

TEACHER PLAN

Lesson 10 (Week 11)

Can We Meet in the Middle?

At a glance · Clock · Steps · Script and answer key

Lesson 10 (Week 11): Can We Meet in the Middle?

At a glance

Objectives: learners can…

- say what they need and ask what the other person needs
- offer a middle idea
- explain a result with *so… that* or *such… that*
- use *work out*, *call off*, or *give in* in a real sentence

Today you will: Say what you need. • Offer a middle idea. • Explain a result with *so… that*.

By the end of class, you can do these four things. Every goal is a good goal.

- I can say what I need and ask what the other person needs.
- I can offer a middle idea.
- I can explain a result with *so… that* or *such… that*.
- I can use *work out*, *call off*, or *give in* in a real sentence.

Materials

- Student pages for Lesson 10 (print for the number expected + 3 spares)
- Board and markers
- Constraint cards: morning class, a family visit, a second job (one card per person in a pair)
- A 4-minute timer for the timekeeper
- Listening: phone + small speaker, L5_L10_listening.mp3 (2:11). No speaker? Read the script aloud with a volunteer.
- **Prep time:** 15 minutes

Key vocabulary (with pictures on the New Words page)

★ compromise • ★ offer • ★ counteroffer • ★ priority • ★ shared task • ★ solution • ★ fairness • ★ sticky note • ★ break time • ★ swap • whiteboard • middle

Clock-time plan

Times are loose. If the listening or Talk Time runs long, take the time from Read & Write.

Time	Step	Min	Grouping (15 / 7–8)	If running behind
6:00–6:06	**Opening Talk + Homework Check**	6	Pairs (one group of 3 if odd)	One card only
6:06–6:12	**New Words** + pair game	6	Whole class, then pairs	Teach the ★ words only
6:12–6:32	**Listening** (play 1 Task A, play 2 Tasks B and C) + Hear it, say it	20	Individuals, then pairs	Do Task C together on the board
6:32–6:45	**Grammar Q&A** + pair check	13	Whole class, then pairs	Skip the pair check
6:45–7:00	BREAK	15		
7:00–7:18	**Talk Time: Saturday Split + Learner Timekeeper**	18	Pairs, then groups of 3	Round 1 only
7:18–7:25	**Read & Write**	7	Pairs read, then individual writing	Questions only; writing is homework
7:25–7:30	**Exit Ticket + Homework**	5	Individuals	**Never skip**

Skip order: (1) the Read & Write writing task; (2) the pair check; (3) the second round of Talk Time. **Never skip** the listening tasks, the grammar boxes and the mistakes table, and the exit ticket.

Attendance: 15 learners: pairs, then groups of 3. 7–8: pairs, then one group of 3 and pairs. 5 or fewer: one group; rotate the timekeeper.

Step by step

Step 1 · 6:00–6:06 · Opening Talk + Homework Check · 6 min

- **Grouping:** pairs, the same partner for both parts. 15 learners: pairs, one group of 3 if odd. 7–8: pairs. 5 or fewer: pairs, or one group with you.
- **Opening Talk:** A asks a card question. B answers in about four sentences. A asks one follow-up. Then switch.
- **Model:** "What must a fair plan do?" Help the learner give a short summary: the answer, a reason, and one detail.
- **Homework Check:** pairs compare one homework item from Lesson 9 (a sentence with *must*, *might*, or *can't*). Write 2 corrections on the board. No names.
- **If behind:** one card only.

Step 2 · 6:06–6:12 · New Words · 6 min

- **Grouping:** whole class, then pairs.
- **Do:** point to each picture and say the word. Learners repeat once. ★ = the most important words.
- **Show the hard words:** an *offer* is your idea; a *counteroffer* is the other person's answer to it. A *priority* is what you need most. *Fairness* means both people keep something. *Swap* means you trade times. The *middle* is the idea between the two needs.
- **Check the meaning:** "Is a compromise one person winning?" (No. A middle idea.) • "Does *give in* take an object here?" (No.) • "Which is right: *so busy that*, or *so busy so*?" (*so busy that*)
- **Partner game:** A points to a picture. B says the word in a sentence. Switch. 15 learners: then 3 teams. 7–8: 2 teams. 5 or fewer: one team against the clock.
- **If behind:** teach the ★ words only.

Step 3 · 6:12–6:32 · Listening + Hear it, say it · 20 min

- **Grouping:** individuals, then pairs. With 5 or fewer, the whole group checks together.
- **Before you listen:** Camila and Jon both need Saturday. Ms. Nguyen asks them to work it out before she calls the shift off.
- **Voices:** Camila, Jon, and Ms. Nguyen. A narrator opens and closes the listening.
- **Play 1 → Task A** (the problem). Pairs compare. Then read Tasks B and C.
- **Play 2 → Tasks B and C.** Pairs compare. Check together.
- **Hear it, say it:** *gonna* and *wanna* are short forms. This listening uses the full forms. You can say *going to* and *want to*. Say each line two times. Stress the offer: *What if WE split the day?* Falling tone on *Let's meet in the middle*.
- **If behind:** do Task C together on the board.

Step 4 · 6:32–6:45 · Grammar Q&A + pair check · 13 min

- **Show it:** two sticky notes on the board, "morning" and "afternoon." Say the other person's idea, then move the notes to a middle plan.
- **Box 1:** offers. *What if we split the day? Let's meet in the middle. I can take the morning if you take the afternoon.*
- **Box 2:** *so* + adjective + *that*; *such* + *a / an* + adjective + noun + *that*.
- **Box 3:** review only: *work it out*, *call it off*, *give in*. Noun after the verb, or *it* in the middle. *Give in* has no object here.
- **Box 4:** *too* is different. *The week is too full for one person.*
- **Rule of thumb:** Say the other person's idea in one sentence before you offer yours. *So* and *such* both mean the result was big enough to cause the next clause.
- **Pair check:** A says a need. B says that idea back, then offers a middle idea. Then switch.
- **Break · 6:45–7:00.** On the board: Say their idea. → Offer a middle. → *so / such … that*.
- **If behind:** skip the pair check. Talk Time practices it.

Step 5 · 7:00–7:18 · Talk Time · 18 min

- **Round 1, Saturday Split (pairs):** each person gets a constraint card (morning class, a family visit, or a second job). They must leave with a written compromise. Say the other person's idea in one sentence before you offer yours.
- **Round 2, Learner Timekeeper (groups of 3):** one learner keeps a 4-minute timer, makes sure both people speak, and reads the compromise aloud. Then rotate the leader.
- **15:** pairs, then groups of 3. **7–8:** pairs, then one group of 3 and pairs. **5 or fewer:** one group; rotate the timekeeper.
- **Do not role-play yelling.** Praise the sentence that repeats the other person's need. Ms. Nguyen only asks them to decide.
- **If behind:** round 1 only.

Step 6 · 7:18–7:25 · Read & Write · 7 min

- **Read:** the team note about shared weekend duties. Pairs answer the five questions.
- **Write:** a 6–8 sentence message to a coworker proposing a compromise, with one *so… that* or *such… that*. Start in class. Finish at home.
- **If behind:** questions only. The writing becomes homework.

Step 7 · 7:25–7:30 · Exit Ticket + Homework · 5 min · NEVER SKIP

- **Exit ticket:** *Describe a small compromise.* Four sentences: what each person needed, the middle idea, a *so / such* result, and why it was fair. Give it to the teacher at the door.
- **Collect.** Sort into yes / almost / not yet. Next class: 2 corrections, no names.
- **Homework (about 20–25 minutes):** do item 1 together. *The week / be / so busy / that / we split Saturday.* → *The week was so busy that we split Saturday.* Bring it next week.

Listening script

2:11. The conversation plays once, so press play again for the second listen. Spoken lines use *going to* and *want to*.

Narrator: Lesson ten. Camila and Jon share a Saturday job. They both want the day off. Ms. Nguyen asks them to work it out before she calls the shift off.

Ms. Nguyen: I don't want to call the shift off. The week was so busy that we need Saturday. Please meet in the middle.

Camila: I want to take the morning off. I have a class, and that class is my priority.

Jon: I hear you. I have a family visit in the afternoon. I was going to ask for the whole day too.

Ms. Nguyen: Say the other person's idea before you offer yours.

Camila: Jon, you need the afternoon for a family visit. I need the morning for my class.

Jon: Yes. What if we split the day? I can take the morning if you take the afternoon.

Camila: That is a fair offer. My class ends at noon. What if we swap at twelve? That is my counteroffer.

Jon: Your counteroffer works. The week was so busy that we split Saturday.

Camila: And it was such a long shift that we shared it. The week is too full for one person.

Jon: The visit is so important that I need the afternoon. This solution is about fairness.

Camila: My class is so important that I need the morning. We didn't give in. We found the middle.

Jon: I'll write the shared task on a sticky note and put it on the whiteboard.

Camila: We each get a break time. I'm going to come in at noon.

Ms. Nguyen: Read the compromise, please. I want to hear it.

Jon: I'm going to work the morning. Camila is going to work the afternoon. We swap at twelve.

Camila: Noon is such a clear time that nobody has to guess.

Ms. Nguyen: You worked it out. I'm not going to call it off. Thank you for the compromise.

Narrator: That's the end of the listening.

Answer key

- *Listening Task A:* **b** (Both need Saturday off.)
- *Listening Task B:* 1 a morning class, 2 an afternoon visit, 3 twelve, 4 such a long shift, 5 a sticky note, 6 not call it off.
- *Listening Task C:* 1 so, 2 such, 3 so, 4 such, 5 so, 6 so.
- *Grammar Practice A:* 1 so, 2 such, 3 too, 4 so, 5 such, 6 it out.
- *Grammar Practice B:* 1 so, 2 such, 3 it out, 4 it off, 5 give in, 6 too.
- *Talk Time:* answers will vary. A good compromise names both needs and one middle time.
- *Homework 1:* The week was so busy that we split Saturday. *Homework 2–4:* answers will vary.
- *Read & Write:* 1 The Saturday shift. 2 A morning class. 3 At noon. 4 On the whiteboard. 5 No. She will not call it off.

- *Exit ticket:* answers will vary. A good answer has four sentences: each person's need, the middle idea, a *so / such* result, and why it was fair.

Teacher notes

- The conflict is a schedule between coworkers, not a complaint against a boss and not a pay dispute. Ms. Nguyen only asks them to decide. Do not role-play yelling.
- Praise the sentence that repeats the other person's need.
- *Give in the argument* is the wrong pattern. *Give in* has no object here.
- *Work it out* and *call it off*: *it* only in the middle. You can also put the noun after: *call the shift off*.
- Invented limits are fine. Do not ask about real pay, a real boss, or a real family problem.
- *gonna* and *wanna* are short forms. This listening uses the full forms.

STUDENT WORKBOOK

Lesson 10 (Week 11)

Can We Meet in the Middle?

Opening Talk · New Words · Listening · Grammar · Talk Time · Homework · Read & Write · Exit Ticket

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Opening Talk

Name: _____ Date: _____

Work with a partner. A asks a card question. B answers in about four sentences. A asks one follow-up. Then switch.

1. What must a fair plan do?	**2.** A page might be an ad. Name one clue.
3. What can't a fair plan ignore?	**4.** Name one Saturday priority.
5. Homework check: one sentence with *must*, *might*, or *can't*.	

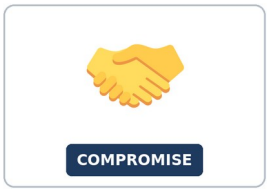
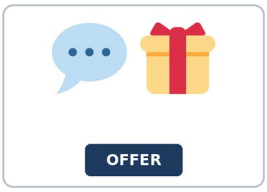
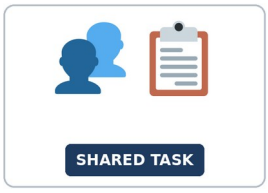
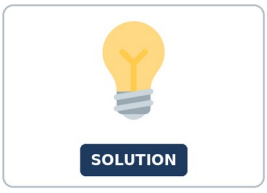
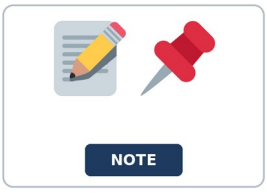
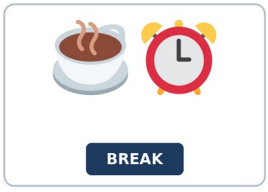
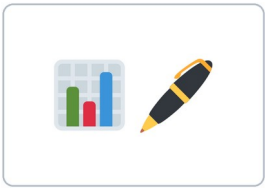
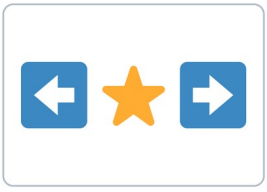
Follow-ups: **What do you need? • Why? • What is a middle idea?**

My partner's name	One need my partner named

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Words

New Words

Look. Listen. Repeat. ★ = most important words.

 ★ **compromise**	 ★ **offer**	 ★ **counteroffer**	 ★ **priority**
 ★ **shared task**	 ★ **solution**	 ★ **fairness**	 ★ **sticky note**
 ★ **break time**	 ★ **swap**	 **whiteboard**	 **middle**

Partner game: Say it in a sentence

Example: A points to **priority**. B says: "My class is my priority." Switch.

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Listening

Camila and Jon both need Saturday. Ms. Nguyen asks them to work it out before she calls the shift off.

Voices: Camila, Jon, and Ms. Nguyen. A narrator opens and closes the listening.

A. Listen. What is the problem? Circle.

a. Camila wants a new job. **b.** Both need Saturday off. **c.** The store is closed.

B. Listen again. Circle the answers.

1. Camila's priority: (**a morning class** / **an afternoon visit** / **a second job**)
2. Jon's limit: (**a morning class** / **an afternoon visit** / **the whiteboard**)
3. They swap at: (**ten** / **twelve** / **four**)
4. The shift was: (**so short** / **such a long shift** / **too easy**)
5. They write the plan on: (**a sticky note** / **a napkin** / **a menu**)
6. Ms. Nguyen is going to: (**call it off** / **not call it off** / **give in**)

C. Listen again. Write *so* or *such*.

1. The week was _____ busy that we split Saturday.
2. It was _____ a long shift that we shared it.
3. The visit is _____ important that I need the afternoon.
4. Noon is _____ a clear time that nobody has to guess.
5. The week was _____ busy that we need Saturday.
6. My class is _____ important that I need the morning.

Hear it, say it

gonna and *wanna* are short forms. This listening uses the full forms. *gonna* = going to. *wanna* = want to. You can say *going to* and *want to*.

Say each line two times:

- I **want to** take the morning off.

- I was **going to** ask for the whole day too.
- I'm **going to** work the morning.
- What if **WE** split the day?

Let's meet in the middle. Use a falling tone. It is a suggestion, not an order.

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Grammar

Read across. The left side is the pattern. The right side is the example.

Grammar Box 1: a middle idea

YOU CAN SAY	A MIDDLE IDEA
What if we split the day?	I can take the morning if you take the afternoon.
Let's meet in the middle.	We can swap at twelve.
Say the other idea first.	You need the afternoon. I need the morning.

Grammar Box 2: *so… that / such… that*

PATTERN	EXAMPLE
so + adjective + *that*	The week was so busy that we split Saturday.
such + *a* + adjective + noun + *that*	It was such a long shift that we shared it.
so + adjective + *that*	The visit is so important that Jon needs the afternoon.
such + *a* + adjective + noun + *that*	Noon is such a clear time that nobody has to guess.

Grammar Box 3: *work out, call off, give in* (review)

REVIEW	A REAL SENTENCE
work it out	We can work it out.
call it off	She is not going to call it off.
call the shift off	Noun after, or *it* in the middle: call it off.
give in	We didn't give in. No object.

Grammar Box 4: don't mix them

DON'T MIX THEM	SAY
so + adjective + *that*	The week was so busy that we split Saturday.
such a + adjective + noun	It was such a long shift that we shared it.
too + adjective + *for*	The week is too full for one person.

Rule of thumb: Say the other person's idea in one sentence before you offer yours. *So* and *such* both mean the result was big enough to cause the next clause.

Questions and answers

Q: Can I say *so busy so we split it*?

A: No. Say *so busy that we split it*.

Q: *So* or *such* before *a long shift*?

A: *Such*. It was such a long shift.

Q: Can I say *give in the argument*?

A: No. *Give in* has no object here.

Practice A: Write *so*, *such*, *too*, or *it out*.

1. The week was _____ busy that we split Saturday.
2. It was _____ a long shift that we shared it.
3. The week is _____ full for one person.
4. The class is _____ important that she needs the morning.
5. It was _____ a fair plan that they both said yes.
6. We can work _____.

Practice B: Circle the correct words.

1. The week was (**so** / **such**) busy that we split it.
2. It was (**so** / **such**) a long shift.
3. Work (**it out** / **out it**).
4. Call (**it off** / **off it**).
5. We didn't (**give in** / **give in the argument**).
6. The week is (**too** / **such**) full for one person.

Common mistakes

Don't say	Say
The week was so busy so we split it.	The week was **so busy that** we split it.
It was so long shift.	It was **such a long shift**.
Give in the argument.	**Give in.** No object here.
Work out it.	**Work it out.**

Pair check

A says a need: "I need the morning for a class." B says it back, then offers: "You need the morning. What if I take the afternoon?" Then switch.

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Talk Time: Saturday Split

Round 1. Pairs. Leave with a written compromise.

Cards: **morning class**, **a family visit**, or **a second job**. Read your card. Say what you need. Say your partner's idea first. Then offer a middle idea. Write the compromise.

My need	My partner's need	Our middle idea

Useful: What if we split the day? • Let's meet in the middle. • I can take the morning if you take the afternoon.

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Talk Time: Learner Timekeeper

Round 2. Groups of 3. One learner keeps the time. 7:00–7:18 for both rounds.

Start a 4-minute timer. Make sure both people speak. Read the compromise aloud. Then rotate the leader.

The compromise, in one or two sentences

15: pairs, then groups of 3. **7–8:** pairs, then one group of 3 and pairs. **5 or fewer:** one group; rotate the timekeeper.

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Homework

Homework (about 20–25 minutes). Bring it next week!

1. Write one *so… that* sentence.

The week / be / so busy / that / we split Saturday. →

_____

2. Finish your message (Read & Write).

☐ I finished it. ☐ It has one *so… that* or *such… that*.

3. Tell a friend a small compromise. Write one sentence they said.

What they needed	The middle idea

4. Review: *work it out, call it off, give in*. Write one real sentence with each.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Read & Write

A. Read the team note.

North Side Market · Team note · Shared Saturday

Our Saturday shift is a shared task. One person cannot cover the whole day. Last month the week was so busy that two people split Saturday. That compromise worked, and the lead did not call the shift off.

This month Camila and Jon wrote a new plan. Camila has a morning class. That class is her priority. Jon has a family visit in the afternoon. They did not give in. They met in the middle. Each person said the other person's idea first, and then made an offer.

Here is the offer on the sticky note. Jon works from eight to twelve. Camila works from twelve to four. They swap at noon. Each person gets one break time. Jon's break is at ten. Camila's break is at two.

They copied the same plan onto the whiteboard in the break room. The note says the solution in one line: morning, Jon; afternoon, Camila. Ms. Nguyen read it. She is not going to call the shift off. She said the plan was fair. She did not pick a winner.

Fairness means both people keep what they need most. It was such a long shift that they shared it. The week is too full for one person. If you have a different limit, write a counteroffer on a new sticky note. Say the other person's idea first. Then offer yours. A second job, a class, or a family visit can all be a real priority. Do not call the shift off by yourself. Bring the note to the lead before Friday. A good message uses *so* or *such*: The morning was so full that we swapped at noon. Or: It was such a long shift that we shared it.

B. Answer the questions.

1. What is the shared task? _____
2. What is Camila's priority? _____
3. When do they swap? _____
4. Where did they copy the plan?

   _____
5. Is Ms. Nguyen going to call the shift off?

   _____

C. Write a 6–8 sentence message to a coworker. Propose a compromise. Use one *so… that* or *such… that*.

My message

Lesson 10 (Week 11) · Exit Ticket

Name: _____ Date: _____

Describe a small compromise. Four sentences.

1. What each person needed.
2. The middle idea.
3. A *so / such* result.
4. Why it was fair.

Give it to me at the door.

My answer
1.
2.
3.
4.

For the teacher	yes	almost	not yet
Four sentences, a middle idea, *so* or *such*	☐	☐	☐

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